

for both shared cultural moments and creator-led, on-demand content,” says the survey. OTT platforms (47%) remain a core entertainment staple, particularly among metro residents, post-graduates and higher-income groups, finds the survey.

The survey further reveals that live and experiential formats scale sharply with income and education. Stand-up comedy (43%) and concerts or live events (35%) show big takers among affluent Gen Z, entrepreneurs and post-graduates, rising to over 60% at higher income levels.

In contrast, lower-income and less-educated cohorts remain more reliant on free or low-cost digital entertainment.

According to YouTube India, this year marked a shift in the universalisation of content irrespective of its original language. “In 2025, content went global, local, and universal all at once. India’s creators are no longer limited by regional nuances; they are building on them.”

Citing an example, YouTube India says that Mr Beast, its most popular content creator globally, didn’t merely visit India this year but “he moved in digitally with his channel gaining over 47 million subscribers”. This became possible because Mr Beast’s content was made available in seven different audio tracks.

THE GEN Z BRANDWAGON

At 380 million, Gen Z is a large, yet not the mainstream, target group for most advertisers because it has yet to emerge as the bread-winner or the primary decision maker when it comes to big-ticket or household expenses.

Still, this generation spends big bucks on personal hygiene and grooming, apparels, fashion accessories and cosmetics, electronics and gadgets, and services such as



“Content is and will always be the king. Be it GenZ or any other generation, good, engaging and relevant content will always find takers”

ASHISH PHERWANI
LEADER, MEDIA &
ENTERTAINMENT SECTOR, EY



“Using influencers to engage with GenZ is quite effective. But the choice of influencers has to be right”

AJIMON FRANCIS
MD, BRAND FINANCE, INDIA

hospitality, travel and indoor as well as outdoor entertainment.

According to estimates, Gen Z consumption, currently, amounts to around ₹1 lakh crore, thus, making it difficult for brands to ignore it or wait till it eventually comes to hold the household purse strings. Besides, brands need to build familiarity and affinity with this customer group for the future, and hence, need to invest in engaging with them even now.

Incidentally, this generation is using social platforms for making purchases too. This has led to “social media driving D2C, or direct-to-consumer, brands in a big way,” says Francis, adding that the “assurance of easy returns, exchanges and refunds is accelerating the phenomenon.”

THE FUTURE

When Gen Z ascends to become the mainstream consumer, the media landscape will likely crystallise into a layered ecosystem where personal will coexist with collective experience. “The future of entertainment is not binary,” says a JioHotStar spokesperson.

Indeed, consumption is likely to remain predominantly mobile-first—unless a newer tech option emerges—and social by default, yet the traditional television screen will retain its utility for “high-impact cultural moments” that demand a shared experience, he says, adding that “platforms that understand and design for this layered behaviour are better positioned to build relevance at scale.”

In other words, it’s not the product but its positioning that requires fresh strategy. Observers say that the product—whether it is a three-hour long film or a 24-hour news cycle—must have the flexibility to be repurposed for myriad short and long format media platforms. **BT**